BRIDE IN THE DESERT

The desperate wanderings that Humayun was forced into through the betrayals of his brothers and the genius of Sher Shah Sur, however, brought about a chance encounter that would change the very shape of the Mughal Empire. In a town in Sind, Humayun met a young woman from a Persian family, Hamida Banu Begum, and decided to make her his wife.

Hamida Banu was only fourteen years old when she received the proposal from the much older wandering Padshah. She maintained a staunch, dignified resistance for forty days, during which Humayun's stepmother, Dildar Begum, gently encouraged the young girl to consider the proposal. Hamida Banu 'resisted and discussed and disagreed' but finally it was settled and Humayun 'took the astrolabe into his own blessed hand and, having chosen a propitious hour', the marriage was celebrated. The bride was, after all, from the family of Ahmad of Jam, just as Humayun had envisioned in a dream, and the planets, it seemed, were finally aligned for glory.

Nevertheless, the immediate future of Humayun's small party was decidedly more grim. They wandered the inhospitable lands of Jodhpur and Jaisalmer, whose local chieftains refused them help, and 'the country through which they fled being an entire sandy desert', we are told by the medieval historian Ferishta, 'the troops began to be in the utmost distress for water. Some ran mad, others fell down dead; nothing was heard but dreadful screams and lamentations.' Hamida Banu, now pregnant with her first child, rode alongside her husband, while their few remaining soldiers ran beside the horses. Horses were scarce at this point and when Humayun asked to borrow a horse from one of his noblemen, Tardi Beg, 'so ungenerous was this man and so low was royalty fallen, that he refused to comply with his request'. The historian William Erskine has a more generous assessment of Tardi Beg who, he believes, 'was a rough old soldier, who kept his own men and cattle in order, and resented any attempt to make him liable for the faults and negligence of others'. But, at last, on a foetid day in August, the party arrived at a small desert town Umerkot where the ruler of the town, Rana Prasad, gave them a gracious welcome.